

90-DAY SOFTWARE TESTING CAREER ROADMAP

Defect Severity vs Priority Guide

Tell these two apart with confidence — and explain them in interviews.

Introduction

Severity is the technical impact of a defect; priority is how soon the business wants it fixed. They are independent, and confusing them leads to the wrong bugs being fixed first.

Definitions

- Severity: how badly it breaks things (crash, data loss vs cosmetic).
- Priority: how urgently the business needs it fixed.

The Four Combinations

Combination	Example
High severity, High priority	Checkout crashes for all users — fix now.
High severity, Low priority	Rare crash on an unused admin screen.
Low severity, High priority	Company name misspelled on the homepage.
Low severity, Low priority	Minor padding issue on a rarely seen page.

Best Practice Tips

- Set severity from technical impact; agree priority with the business.
- Always be ready with a mismatch example (low severity, high priority).
- Keep the two as separate fields in your tracker.

Common Mistakes

- Treating severity and priority as the same thing.
- Marking everything critical.
- Setting priority without business input.

INSIDE STLC PRO TIP

"A homepage typo is low severity but high priority" is the single best line to nail this interview question — memorise it.